FANG FICTION

Kiss of the Vampire **sits within a long and fascinating tradition of Hammer horror films and depictions of vampires. Jonathan Nunns sinks his teeth into some historical context.**



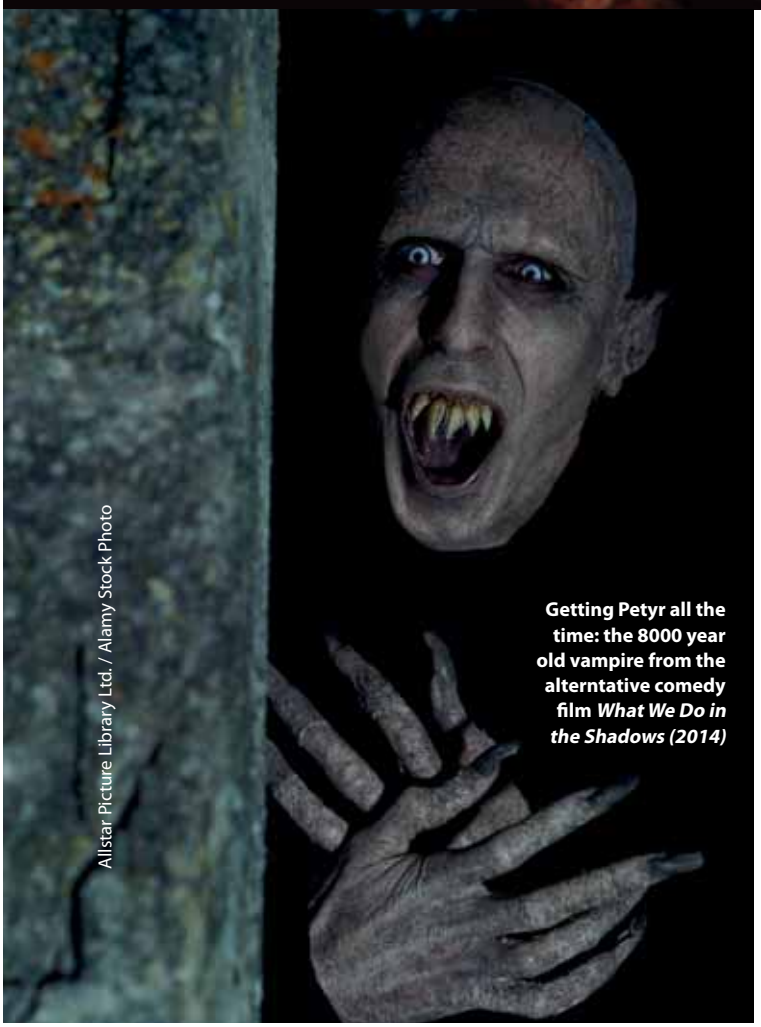
Dracula back with a bang: Claes Bang in Mark Gatiss and Steven Moffat's 2019 reinvention

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TCD/Prod.DB / Alamy Stock Photo

Tall, powerful and very British – Christopher Lee as Dracula



Allstar Picture Library Ltd. / Alamy Stock Photo

Getting Petyr all the time: the 8000 year old vampire from the alterntative comedy film *What We Do in the Shadows (2014)*

The vampire has been iconic in western culture for generations. Popularised by Bram Stoker's 1897 book *Dracula*, the myths surrounding the undead antagonists long predate the hit novel. One such story concerns the exploits of the fifteenth century Romanian knight Vlad the Impaler, otherwise known as Vlad Dracula, the name Stoker would later adopt for his fictional fiend.

Since the development of film and TV, each generation has created its own version of these immortal monsters, starting with *Nosferatu* (Murnau,1922). In this silent film, (a lightly disguised version of the *Dracula* novel – character names and places were changed to avoid copyright), the vampire was a rat-like creature, both inhuman and repulsive, as in Stoker's novel.

Other incarnations followed, including Universal Studios early sound film *Dracula* (Browning, 1931). Whilst the film reclaimed the iconic name, the look of Dracula was dramatically re-tooled. The vampire was now a suave and exotic Eastern European Count. The bloodless (and fangless) film substituted the sex appeal and matinee idol looks of the star Bela Lugosi, for the bloodshed


The TERRIFYING Lover—
who died – yet lived!
Universal-International presents A Hammer Film Production
PETER CUSHING
DRACULA
(Cert. X Adults only
MICHAEL GOUGH
MELISSA STRIBLING
CHRISTOPHER LEE .. Dracula
In Eastman Colour processed by Technicolor
Screenplay by JIMMY SANGSTER Associate Producer ANTHONY NELSON-KEYS
Produced by ANTHONY HINDS Directed by TERENCE FISHER
Executive Producer MICHAEL CARRERAS
Distributed by Rank Film Distributors Ltd.
DON'T DARE SEE IT ALONE!

Christopher Lee's tall, powerful (and very British) version of the Count, defined the character for decades, created a very successful franchise for Hammer and made the antagonist the focal point of the film.

usually associated with the character. The film is now remembered for creating the classic characterisation: evening dress, cape, slicked back hair and Eastern European accent. Later versions include Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (Coppola,1992) and all manner of recent vampire incarnations, often derived from popular novels such as *Interview with the Vampire* (Jordan, 2004) and, more famously, *Twilight* (Hardwicke, 2008) which went on to become a hugely successful tweenage franchise. Recent postmodern reinventions of the vampire have included the successful mockumentary hybrid, *What We Do In The Shadows* (Waititi, 2014) and the BBC's own recent TV offering, *Dracula* (BBC, 2019), created by Steven Moffat and Mark Gatiss, well known for their successful re-inventions of other iconic characters with *Doctor Who* and *Sherlock*.

Prince of Darkness

However, the most famous and influential version of the vampire was created for Hammer Studios' *Dracula* (Fisher, 1958). Christopher Lee's tall, powerful (and very British) version of the Count, defined the character for decades, created a very successful franchise for Hammer and made the antagonist the focal point of the film (see the original poster art). So, considering the iconic status of that film and Lee's defining image, it may seem strange that Eduqas choose the little known or remembered *Dracula* second sequel, *Kiss of the Vampire* (Sharp, 1963) as it's featured vintage movie poster case study.

The film in both title and script, avoids any reference to the famous Dracula character, despite his having served Hammer so well. So, what can we learn from this vintage example of film marketing?

Whilst it may not use the Dracula name, it certainly assumes the demographic will be familiar with the earlier films. In terms of Neale's genre theory, the poster design carefully includes many signifiers of the Gothic vampire film. The vampire bats, remote castle, full moon and low key/high contrast chiaroscuro lighting are all clear signifiers of the sub-genre. The 'wooden' look of the font used for the title and bloodied 'fang' reflects vampire lore, (the rules of the genre e.g. vampires cast no reflection and are repulsed by garlic). In this case, the reference is both to vampires feeding on blood and to a means of their destruction, the stake through the heart. So, the signifiers are used to ensure audiences would be in no doubt as to what they would get. The blood and the prominently displayed Hammer name/brand, would be further reinforcement of the product offered. Hammer Studios were, by the early 1960's, the most successful studio in Horror, exporting their economically made British shockers across the world. The blood would also be a reminder of what Hammer had done to reinvent the genre. Hammer, in its day was ground breaking and controversial, pushing at the limits of what censorship and classification would allow. The banner reference to Eastman Color reminds audiences that the film would be vibrant, in saturated colour when many films were still made in black and white. The American spelling of Color indicates Hammer's international success. This is a poster for the US market, showing Hammer had successfully broken into the most lucrative movie marketplace in the world. The inclusion of the Universal logo indicates the American Studio's role as US distributor of the film and offered the more cine-literate members of the audience a call-back to Universal's own great horror franchises, such as *Frankenstein* (Whale,1931) and the original Lugosi Dracula. In terms of quality, the poster reminded audiences that *Kiss of the Vampire* might not be Dracula, but was brought to them by the two greatest studios in horror.

A modern movie poster would be much more photo-real in representing the stars and the production values, demonstrating more fully the USP of the film it promoted. The use of an artistic, non-photo-real approach to the *Kiss of the Vampire* key art, demonstrates the technological limitations of the early 1960's. Artistic rendering of a film's USP was the norm and would be for many years to come. Only with modern computers/software would photo-real rendering of film content become available to distributors.

The *Kiss of the Vampire* poster is a set text for Eduqas A level Media



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A Deadly Kiss

The representation of the four characters featured in the poster is interestingly different to what modern audiences might expect but in keeping with Hammer's offer. The heightened emotion and non-verbal communication (body-language) of the characters was at one with the Hammer USP. They were the edgy and subversive 'rock and roll' of modern cinema in comparison with the too-restrained, repressed, documentary realist traditions of mainstream British film. Hammer wanted to offer horror fans an emotional 'rush' and their artwork made this clear. The period costumes quickly established the era of the action. The poster features no protagonists. Instead there are vampire antagonists and sacrificial prey. The strength of the male vampire is demonstrated through his one-handed grip on the female victim, whose tight-fitting costume and exposed flesh offers male gaze pleasures and conforms with the conventional sexist norms of gender performativity for the time. However, the male vampire is also recoiling from the more powerful female antagonist. Sexualised by her costume it seems that it is she who is about to deliver on the promised 'vampire kiss' of the title. This depiction, whilst sexualised, is strikingly at odds with earlier representations of women in horror advertising, who were almost uniformly the prey to male monsters. The 1960s were a period of profound change in the social norms of British life. Women began to seek greater equality and as bell hooks discusses, in that time they began to mobilise to achieve it. The representation of the female vampire is contradictory. Lines of sight show she is sexualised and on display, yet central to the narrative. She has at her mercy a passive male victim, throat exposed ready for her attack. Head tipped back he is effectively faceless, an everyman threatened, like the male vampire, by the 'danger' of the newly empowered woman. It is interesting that Hammer refers to female empowerment, demonstrating cultural relevance to attract female audiences but doing so in a way that exposed male fears. Feminism is presented as a threat to patriarchal power. As the male vampire, a traditional avatar of masculine strength recoils in fear, only the attacking bat restrains her assault on her emasculated prey.

Kiss of the Vampire is a little-remembered minor Hammer release. However, it is the poster that is important, not the film. In terms of content, it encapsulates Hammer's strengths as a studio, its international success and dominance of the horror genre. It also demonstrates the shifting norms of a time of rapid change, in which gothic horror, like all good genres, was changing to reflect the social realities of the time the films were made, rather than the era in which they were set.

In these terms, as a time capsule and a study of the film marketing of the 1960s, *Kiss of the Vampire* makes absolute sense. It is a harbinger of profound change, both empowering to some and terrifying to others.

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from the MM vaults

Not Just the House of Horror – Mark Ramey, *MM*46
Dracula Dynasty and Dracula Revisited – Gareth Calway, *MM*18 and *MM*20
Revisioning the Vampire – Sean Richardson, *MM*31



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